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Presentation Skills

In the world of business, oral presentations are considered very important to communicate or deliver a message. Companies or business firms arrange oral presentations to achieve different goals and objectives. Sometimes these presentations are held to inform people about new products policies, or changes which take place. Sometimes business organizations arrange presentations to persuade people. And sometimes the purpose of a presentation is to entertain. To achieve these aims and objectives, the presenter must keep some steps and requirements at the time of preparing and delivering an oral presentation.

Steps of Presentation

An activity that many of us view with concern is that of giving presentations. Few people feel entirely comfortable standing in front of an audience to deliver a talk; even fewer actually enjoy it. In fact, a survey carried out in America on common fears, suggested that fear of speaking in front of a group was rated higher than fear of death (Rasberry & Lemoine, 1986)! The reasons behind this are simple- people fear that public speaking may result in humiliation, embarrassment or loss of dignity. Even the most adept speakers recognize feelings of fear in anticipation of and during delivery of a presentation. However, the key to success is to utilize that fear and to recognize it as a normal, healthy feeling. There is nothing wrong with feeling a level of anxiety and in fact, learning to harness the energy it produces can help you to perform well. It is also important to have realistic expectations of ourselves. Few of us possess the ability to perform theatrically, or entertain large audiences with witty one-liners and clever tales. However, giving effective presentations does not require these abilities. Clear, competent 'plain speaking' delivered with an air of confidence will suffice (Wells, 1986).

Styles of presentation will be influenced by the context, but also by the person's preferred way of doing it, which may be developed over time. Remember however, the quality of many presentations is determined by the work put in before you even begin to speak.

Dealing with Fears

As we have seen, a common fear is that the presentation will result in some sort of disaster, leaving us feeling embarrassed or humiliated. Once explored however, these fears usually emerge as unrealistic and our imagined 'worst case scenario' is either highly unlikely or not the catastrophic disaster that we think it will be!

Techniques to resolve your anxiety include the following:

• Accept that it is perfectly normal to feel nervous or anxious to some extent.

• Prepare well.

• Be realistic.

Are your standards too high? Take off the unnecessary pressure that comes from negative and unrealistic thoughts by challenging them and seeking the more rational view. That worst case

scenario you imagine is highly improbable, and if a less than positive outcome does occur, it is unlikely to be the end of the world!

• Use relaxation exercises such as deep breathing.

• Behave 'as if' you are feeling confident; i.e.

i. Enter the presentation in a very deliberate way,
ii. Rehearse your presentation, but also how you will Stand, set out your notes, change your slides etc,
iii. Use other non-verbal behaviors to appear confident (See section on delivery of the presentation). (Adapted from Hartley & Bruckman, 2002)

Planning Your Presentation

It can be helpful to plan your presentation in terms of key steps, as follows:

1. **Set your objective**. A simple sentence can be a good means of defining your purpose in giving the presentation, and will begin to determine the content. Try to complete the following sentence:

   'As a result of my presentation, my audience will….'

   For example, 'As a result of my presentation, my audience will see their role in interdisciplinary learning more clearly, and will understand and be impressed with the value of providing practice placements in this department.'

   Decide whether the main purpose of your talk is to inform, persuade, motivate or change things. What do you want your audience to do as a result of your talk?

   Let's discuss these three purposes in detail.

   (a) To inform:
   An informative speech conveys facts, using clear examples and supporting material. It aims to develop ideas, passes on information and shows how something works or can be done. Balance the content and discussion to achieve an unbiased and objective presentation.

   (b) To persuade:
   A persuasive speech establishes a need in the audience and explains the action required to satisfy the need. A persuasive speech aims to influence the audience, to change their attitude or bring them round to a particular point of view.

   (c) To entertain:
   An entertaining speech uses a variety of techniques such as humor, anecdotes, examples and quotations around a common theme so that the audience may enjoy the presentation. As a speaker, you may decide to combine informative or persuasive elements with entertainment.

2. **Understand your audience:** Try and have a basic idea of the size of the audience and who they are. Think about what they will be expecting from the presentation, but be realistic about this. Find out what level of knowledge and experience those attending will have about your topic, so that you know where to aim the material. Are the audience likely to have any preconceptions or misconceptions about the subject that you need to address and put right? How might your audience use what you have to say?

3. **Know your setting**: Find out about the equipment – audiovisual aids etc. that will be available. Check out the location of the presentation; the size of the room (to help you decide on type of seating arrangements), and other facilities.

4. Write down the 'central theme' of the talk. For example, using the example given in point 1, the theme or overall message might be: 'Interdisciplinary learning opportunities are vital to student placements, form a valuable part of the work of the department and each member of staff has an important role to play'.

5. Write your outline: Ask yourself: What are the main points I need to make to get my message across? What supporting information will I need? Where will I get this? How much time will I need? Structure your talk (see section on structuring your talk).

6. Develop your visual aids: For example, will you use a flipchart, whiteboard powerpoint, overhead projector or data projector etc. to clarify important points and aid understanding? NB: Do not use too many slides/points.

7. Prepare your delivery notes, according to the structured outline.

8. Deliver your presentation (see section on delivery). (Adapted from Gallagher et al, 1998)

NB. Often, presenters with little experience imagine that their audience is waiting for them to fail and that the slightest mistake will result in derision. This just does not happen. Try to remember that the audience is made up of people like you, who want you to do well. Most people will feel a sense of empathy with you and will be understanding if you run into difficulties. Try to take off the unnecessary pressure that comes from negative and unrealistic thoughts, by seeking the more rational view.

Structuring Your Presentation

This is perhaps one of the most important aspects of the presentation. The structure should be clear to both you and your audience. Different authors advocate different formats for structuring a presentation, each of which has their merits (Hartley and Bruckman, 2002;

Hargie et al, 2004; Adler and Elmhorst, 1999). In simplest terms however, a presentation should have an introduction, body and conclusion.

Introduction: Through the introduction you should grab your audience's attention and set the scene. Ways of getting your audience's attention include asking a rhetorical or intriguing question, providing a relevant and interesting fact, giving an anecdote, outlining the valuable information you hope the audience will gain from the presentation/telling them why they need to know the information, giving a quote or making a dramatic prediction.

Your theme should be made clear from the start. Start the audience thinking about the subject matter of your presentation by, for example, a statement of your main objective. It can also be helpful to present the structure to your talk, by explaining briefly how you plan to proceed with it.

The Main Body: Select the main points that support your argument but only include as much detail as your audience needs. Also, be aware that people will not remember too many points. Once you have decided on the key points, organize them into a sequence that makes sense to you. This sequence may take various forms, including being chronologically based, problem-solution based, simple-complex based etc. (Hargie et al, 2004; Adler and Elmhorst, 1999). Explain and build your points using supporting information and evidence.

Conclusion: There are various ways of concluding a presentation including changing the pace, using a new visual aid, summarizing your main points, drawing the conclusion and its importance, making recommendations, asking for questions, getting feedback, asking for or recommending particular actions, getting some sort of commitment from the group to the advocated course of action, or ending by thanking the group for their time and attention. Do not end suddenly. Give your audience some idea that you are coming to a close; eg. 'And now, before I finish' or 'In conclusion' etc. Try to end on a strong note through the use of tactics detailed above. Research has long since shown that we tend to remember the opening and closing parts of a presentation over the detail in the middle.

Delivering Your Presentation

Having prepared the presentation, the time comes of its delivery. It is a very important stage which determines success or failure of a presentation. While delivering the presentation, the presenter must keep the following points in his mind.

i) Confidence

Confidence is the most important thing which a person needs to face an audience. It helps you to win people and to persuade them. While standing in front of an audience, confidence helps you to convey and transmit your ideas in a proper way. This is key

element through which you can convince people. Confidence can be achieved through your grasp over the topic.

ii) **Appearance** at the time of delivering a presentation, your appearance plays a vital role to make others believe that you have the ability and something with you. A well and neatly dressed person leaves a good impact on the mind of audience and he succeeds to get the attraction of the audience.

iii) **Eye Contact** The importance of eye contact is paramount. By keeping a good eye-contact with your audience, you leave a good impression. If you are shy and don't look at the audience, they will not pay interest and attention to your words.

iv) **Voice Quality** The role of your voice is of great importance. Particularly at the time of delivering the presentation your voice should not be too low or too high but you must be audible to everyone. Your tone should be cheerful and it should never be unpleasant.

v) **Posture** The way people stand or sit can say a lot of how they feel. The posture of a person projects his personality as well as his inner strength or weakness. It leaves a strong impression on the minds of the listeners. Speaker should stand at the place where a good number of people can look at him.

vi) **Word Rate** Our thinking capacity is much higher than our speaking capacity. While talking to people, a person should not speak too fast or too slow. The accepted rate that our senses may accept easily is 80 to 160 words per minute. The speaker must keep this figure in his mind.

vii) **Pronunciation** How does a person pronounce the words? Pronunciation is a striking feature of an oral presentation. If you don't pronounce the words properly, your whole effort goes waste. Wrong pronunciation leaves a bad impact on the audience, and develops a humorous and non-serious atmosphere among the listeners.

Methods of Delivering Oral Presentation

There are four basic methods (sometimes called styles) of presenting a speech: manuscript, memorized, extemporaneous, and impromptu. Each has a variety of uses in various forms of communication

I- Extemporaneous Method
II- Manuscript – Reading Method
III- Memorization Method
IV- Impromptu Method Methods of Delivery

Manuscript Style

The word manuscript is the clue to the style. The speech is written and the speaker reads it word for word to the audience. Originally, it was done from the hand-written paper manuscript. Today the manuscript style is common, but the paper is gone. Who reads the speech to the audience? Answer: Newscasters and television personalities. In the old days, the manuscript was hand-lettered on cue cards, which were held next to the camera lens. Then paper scrolls, like printed piano rolls were used, especially in Soap Operas. Today, a special teleprompter (working like a periscope) is attached to the camera so the newscaster is looking at the lens while reading.

Why is the manuscript important and in use? Precision. In the news- reporting industry, every fraction of a second counts because broadcast time is costly. Also, the facts and names must be exact and accurate so there is no room for error. Errors in reporting decrease the credibility of the news organization and the newscaster.

The most regular use of the teleprompter for manuscript delivery is by the U.S. President. In fact, the teleprompter, used by every President since Reagan, is called a “Presidential Teleprompter.” It is made of two pieces of glass, each flanking the podium. They reflect the text from a monitor on the floor like periscope. The glass on both sides has the same text, and the speaker looks alternately from one glass to the other as though looking at the audience through the glass. The audience cannot see the projected text. The speeches a President gives will often reflect national policy, define international relationships, and the press will scrutinize every syllable. It has to be more than brilliantly accurate; it has to be impeccably phased. Professional writers and policy experts compose the speech; and the President delivers it as though he not only wrote it, but made it up on the spot. That is the skill of a good politician, actor, or speaker. Those who are not skilled using a teleprompter or manuscript will sound stilted and boring.

Try This! Manuscript Delivery Watch the local or national 6 p.m., 11 p.m. and 6 a.m. newscasts on the same T.V. station. Make notes on which news items repeat and how closely, or exactly, the phrasing is, even if different personalities are presenting the same item.

Memorized Style The memorized style of speaking is when the manuscript is committed to memory and recited to the audience verbatim (word for word). In the days when elocution was taught, this was a typical approach. A speech was a recitation. The Optimists Club (a national organization) used to have a “Oratory” contest for high school students. Contestants wrote essays on a given theme, to create a speech at a specific time length (e.g.: three minutes). The essay was memorized and the delivery was judged by 1) the quality of the writing, 2) the accuracy with which it was recited; and 3) the precise length of time. Such contests seem archaic by today’s more casual and somewhat less formal standards. Where is a memorized delivery style still common? Due to copyright laws and licensing contract agreements (other than scripts that are in the public domain), actors on stage are obligated to memorize the script of the play and perform it verbatim exactly as written. It is typical for speakers on high school and university speech and debate teams to memorize their competitive speeches. Corporate conventions often use large LCD monitors on the

front of the stage as teleprompters. This allows the speaker to move more freely across the stage while sticking to his or her script. Some monologists (such as the stand-up comics mentioned at the start of the chapter) also use a memorized delivery style. In all cases, they create the impression that the speech is spontaneous. You might consider using the memorized delivery style if your speech is relatively short, or you know you will have to deliver your speech repeatedly such as a tour operator would.

Impromptu Style

Theoretically, an "impromptu" speech is "made up on the spot." It is unprepared and unrehearsed. Often ceremonial toasts, grace before meals, an acknowledgement, an introduction, offering thanks and so on, fall into this category. While there are some occasions when a speech in those categories is actually prepared (prepare your acceptance for the Academy Award BEFORE you are called!), there are many occasions when there is little or no opportunity to prepare. Impromptu speeches are generally short and are often given with little or no notice. Notes are rare and the speaker generally looks directly at the audience. It would be presumptuous and arrogant to declare rules for Impromptu Speaking. It is fair to explain that "impromptu" describes a range from absolutely no preparation, to a modest amount of preparation (mostly thought) and rarely incorporates research or the formalities of outlines and citations that more formal speeches would include.

Extemporaneous Style

Sandwiched between the memorized and impromptu delivery styles you find the extemporaneous speech style. For this style, the speech is not completely written out. It is usually delivered with keynotes for reference. Most public speaking courses and books describe extemporaneous speeches as carefully prepared and rehearsed, but delivered using notes of key words and phrases to support the speaker. Phrasing is pre- rehearsed, words are pre-chosen, and the organization is fluid and well-constructed. There should be no fumbling for words, no rambling, and length of time should be carefully monitored. The style does offer the speaker flexibility to include references to the immediate surroundings, previous speeches, news of the day, and so on.

How you develop the notes and what they look like are up to the individual, but a natural extemporaneous delivery is difficult if you are relying on a manuscript. Under no circumstances should the speaker be spending more than 20% of the speaking time looking at the notes. It would be ideal to practice so you only glance at your notes approximately 5% of the time of the speech.

Techniques of delivering a Presentation

Hargie et al (2004, p. 72) outline a number of features of effective deliveries, summarized as follows:

• **Use appropriate language and avoid jargon.** If the audience do not understand most of what is being talked about, they will become detached.

• **Be suitably paced.** Inexperienced speakers have a habit of speaking too quickly. On the other hand, speaking too slowly is a recipe for boredom. Where speed of delivery may be a particular

concern, think about placing an accomplice in the audience primed to signal when you get too slow or too quick.

Use visual aids without placing them center stage. Even the best of these are only aids to assist the speaker.

• Make use of sub-summaries, signposts and links. Pause at transitional points in the flow of ideas to briefly summarize the material covered. Explaining how this 'chunk' of information links with what comes next helps to signpost the path through the presentation and increases its coherence**.**

• Emphasize key points verbally, non-verbally and vocally. Emphasize verbally through listing key points (e.g. 'It is vital that you recognize…'), repeating core elements etc; non-verbally (e.g. Gestures, changes in posture, position); and vocally (e.g. Altering volume, speed of delivery, tone of voice).

• Be verbally fluent. Effective public speakers do not have to be word perfect. Nevertheless, lots of 'umms' 'ahhhhs' and other fillers such as 'you know' can be highly distracting.

• Be concrete and precise, rather than appearing vague and indefinite

. • Be dynamic: Use punchy rhetoric, vocal variation and non-verbal animation. If you are not enthused, how can you expect to be sufficiently enlivened to enthuse others?

• Be varied, e.g. intersperse talk with graphs, slides or pieces of video that the audience can look at as a break from listening. If appropriate, encourage some discussion or ask the audience to work on a brief exercise**.**

• Include carefully chosen examples – as a bridge between what the listener knows and is familiar with and the new material being introduced**.**

• Avoid distractions, e.g. pacing around, playing with a pen or pointer, over use of certain stock phrases. Gain control of body language**.**

• Seem natural and not contrived. This can take some time and practice.

• Rehearse what is going to be said. A Final Word on Body Language: Remember the importance of non-verbal communication! While skills such as concise expression of plain english, logical association of ideas and organised speech are important, they do not ensure that effective communication will take place. Behave enthusiastically, make and maintain eye contact, smile, act 'as if' you are confident and relaxed (even if you do not feel it) and make your introduction without reading from your notes too much. The manner of speech is also important. As well as ensuring that your voice can be heard by the furthest member of the group, speak clearly and at a conversational, appropriate speed. Varying the tone, pitch, rate and other vocal features can communicate enthusiasm and can create a sense of interest in the listener. Pause before key points and stress key parts of the sentence by using change in tone.